

IELTS Reading Support Worksheet

For Band 4-5 / B1 students who need extra practice

Lesson aims

1. Skim for the general idea before answering questions.
2. Scan for names, dates, places, numbers, and key words.
3. Find synonyms / paraphrases between questions and the text.
4. Locate evidence before choosing or writing the answer.

Class rule

Do not guess first. For every answer, underline the sentence in the passage and circle the synonym / paraphrase.

Section A - Note Completion

Questions 1-12. Complete the notes. Use **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER** from the passage for each answer. Reading Passage 1: Patrick Malone (Part 1)

Patrick Malone is a traveller, writer and broadcaster. He was born in 1968 in Basel, Switzerland, where his British parents were working for a pharmaceutical company. His family left Switzerland when he was twelve, and returned to their home in Britain. For the next six years, Malone attended the local secondary school. He then went to Leeds University to do a course in Human Geography. He wanted to become a town planner. However, the only work he could find was as a teacher at a local school.

During his holidays and free time, he went walking, often covering very long distances very quickly. On one occasion he walked the entire length of Britain, a distance of over 1,400 kilometres, in less than a month. He enjoyed the experience and the challenge so much that he started walking in different parts of the world, usually in fairly remote areas away from major population centres. The people he met and the experiences he had on these trips provided him with some excellent material for his classes.

It was during one trip that he met his old university tutor, Don Perkins. At the time, Perkins was putting together a team of geographers and biologists for a research trip to the Amazon, and asked Malone if he would like to go with them. The expedition was for a whole year, and so he had to give up his job at the school, but Malone did not hesitate to accept Perkins' offer. He sold his car to make some money, bought an airline ticket for Brazil and set off.

Complete the timeline below.

1. Moved to _____ when he was twelve.
2. Studied _____ at university.
3. Got a job as a _____.
4. Once travelled more than _____ on foot on a single trip.
5. Often went walking in places that were quite _____.
6. Joined an _____ to the Amazon.

Name: _____ Date: _____ Score: _____ / 34

Reading Passage 2: Patrick Malone (Part 2)

The Amazon expedition, which took six months and covered a distance of almost 2,500 kilometres, was a great success. The group discovered some new plant and insect species, as well as a forest tribe which people had never heard of. Malone enjoyed the trip so much that he decided to become a full-time explorer. He earned money by writing travel articles for magazines and newspapers, which he illustrated with his own photographs.

In 1996, he married Margaret Logan, an American doctor he had met while travelling around Africa. In 1998 they had Adam, the first of three children; twins Amelia and Jennifer were born a year later. Many families at this stage would settle down, but Margaret and Patrick decided to keep travelling, spending two years walking around India and another twelve months exploring the islands of Indonesia.

When they returned home, they wrote a magazine article about travelling with small children. It was so popular that they were asked to write several more articles on the same subject. This was followed by an offer from a television company to present a TV series about travelling with children. The series ran for 12 years, and won several television awards. Today they still make the most of every opportunity to travel, and have recently returned from the South Pacific.

Complete the second timeline below.

7. _____ a tribe that nobody knew existed.
8. _____ someone he met on a trip.
9. They had _____: Adam, Amelia and Jennifer.
10. Explored the Indonesian islands for _____.
11. Made a successful _____.
12. Still likes to _____ whenever possible.

Section B - True / False / Not Given

Questions 13-19. Write *TRUE* if the statement agrees with the text, *FALSE* if the statement contradicts the text, or *NOT GIVEN* if there is no information.

Reading Passage 3: Mau Piaiug, ocean navigator

Mau sailed from Hawaii to Tahiti using traditional methods.

In early 1976, Mau Piaiug, a fisherman, led an expedition in which he sailed a traditional Polynesian boat across 2,500 miles of ocean from Hawaii to Tahiti. The Polynesian Voyaging Society had organised the expedition. Its purpose was to find out if seafarers in the distant past could have found their way from one island to the other without navigational instruments, or whether the islands had been populated by accident. At the time, Mau was the only man alive who knew how to navigate just by observing the stars, the wind and the sea. He had never before sailed to Tahiti, which was a long way to the south. However, he understood how the wind and the sea behave around islands, so he was confident he could find his way. The voyage took him and his crew a month to complete and he did it without a compass or charts.

His grandfather began the task of teaching him how to navigate when he was still a baby. He showed him pools of water on the beach to teach him how the behaviour of the waves and wind changed in different places. Later, Mau used a circle of stones to memorise the position of the stars. Each stone was laid out in the sand to represent a star.

The voyage proved that Hawaii's first inhabitants came in small boats and navigated by reading the sea and the stars. Mau himself became a keen teacher, passing on his traditional secrets to people of other cultures so that his knowledge would not be lost. He explained the positions of the stars to his students, but he allowed them to write things down because he knew they would never be able to remember everything as he had done.

13. At the time of his voyage, Mau had unique navigational skills. _____
14. Mau was familiar with the sea around Tahiti. _____
15. Mau thought it would be difficult to use a compass and charts. _____
16. Mau's grandfather was his only teacher. _____
17. Mau used stones to learn where each star was situated in the sky. _____
18. The first inhabitants of Hawaii could read and write. _____
19. Mau expected his students to memorise the positions of the stars. _____

Section C - Matching Headings

Questions 20-24. Choose the correct heading for each paragraph from the list of headings. There are two headings you do not need.

Reading Passage 4: Traffic jams - no end in sight

There are no easy answers to the problems of traffic congestion.

A Traffic congestion affects people throughout the world. Traffic jams cause smog in dozens of cities across both the developed and developing world. In the US, commuters spend an average of a full working week each year sitting in traffic jams, according to the Texas Transportation Institute. While alternative ways of getting around are available, most people still choose their cars because they are looking for convenience, comfort and privacy.

B The most promising technique for reducing city traffic is called congestion pricing, whereby cities charge a toll to enter certain parts of town at certain times of day. In theory, if the toll is high enough, some drivers will cancel their trips or go by bus or train. And in practice it seems to work: Singapore, London and Stockholm have reduced traffic and pollution in city centres thanks to congestion pricing.

C Another way to reduce rush-hour traffic is for employers to implement flexitime, which lets employees travel to and from work at off-peak traffic times to avoid the rush hour. Those who have to travel during busy times can do their part by sharing cars. Employers can also allow more staff to telecommute (work from home) so as to keep more cars off the road altogether.

D Some urban planners still believe that the best way to ease traffic congestion is to build more roads, especially roads that can take drivers around or over crowded city streets. But such techniques do not really keep cars off the road; they only accommodate more of them.

E Other, more forward-thinking, planners know that more and more drivers and cars are taking to the roads every day, and they are unwilling to encourage more private automobiles when public transport is so much better both for people and the environment. For this reason, the American government has decided to spend some \$7 billion on helping to increase capacity on public-transport systems and upgrade them with more efficient technologies. But environmentalists complain that such funding is tiny compared to the \$50 billion being spent on roads and bridges.

No.	Heading
i	A solution which is no solution
ii	Changing working practices
iii	Closing city centres to traffic
iv	Making cars more environmentally friendly
v	Not doing enough
vi	Paying to get in
vii	A global problem

20. Paragraph A _____
21. Paragraph B _____
22. Paragraph C _____
23. Paragraph D _____
24. Paragraph E _____

Section D - Matching Headings

Questions 25-29. Choose the correct heading for each paragraph from the list of headings. There are two headings you do not need.

Reading Passage 5: Pedestrians only

How traffic-free shopping streets developed.

A The concept of traffic-free shopping areas goes back a long time. During the Middle Ages, traffic-free shopping areas known as souks were built in Middle Eastern countries to allow people to shop in comfort and, more importantly, safety. As far back as 2,000 years ago, road traffic was banned from central Rome during the day to allow for the free movement of pedestrians, and was only allowed in at night when shops and markets had closed for the day. In most other cities, however, pedestrians were forced to share the streets with horses, coaches and, later, with cars and other motorised vehicles.

B The modern, traffic-free shopping street was born in Europe in the 1960s, when both city populations and car ownership increased rapidly. Dirty exhaust fumes from cars and the risks involved in crossing the road were beginning to make shopping an unpleasant and dangerous experience. Many believed the time was right for experimenting with car-free streets, and shopping areas seemed the best place to start.

C At first, there was resistance from shopkeepers. They believed that such a move would be bad for business. They argued that people would avoid streets if they were unable to get to them in their cars. When the first streets in Europe were closed to traffic, there were even noisy demonstrations, and many shopkeepers predicted they would lose customers.

D However, research carried out afterwards in several European cities revealed some unexpected statistics. In Munich, Cologne and Hamburg, visitors to shopping areas increased by 50 percent. On Copenhagen's main shopping street, shopkeepers reported sales increases of 25-40 percent. Shopkeepers in Minneapolis, USA, were so impressed when they learnt this that they even offered to pay for the construction and maintenance costs of their own traffic-free street.

E With the arrival of the traffic-free shopping street, many shops, especially those selling things like clothes, food and smaller luxury items, prospered. Unfortunately, it was not good news for everyone, and shops selling furniture and larger electrical appliances actually saw their sales drop. Many of these were forced to move elsewhere, away from the city centre. Today they are a common feature on the outskirts of towns and cities, often situated in out-of-town retail zones with their own car parks and other local facilities.

No.	Heading
i	Facing local opposition
ii	Some reasons for success
iii	Winners and losers
iv	A need for change
v	An experiment that went wrong
vi	An idea from ancient history
vii	North America learns from Europe

25. Paragraph A _____

26. Paragraph B _____

27. Paragraph C _____

28. Paragraph D _____

29. Paragraph E _____

Section E - Multiple Choice

Questions 30-34. Choose the correct letter A, B, C or D.

Reading Passage 6: Air conditioning

The history of an invention that makes life more pleasant.

Willis Carrier designed the first air-conditioning unit in 1902, just a year after graduating from Cornell University with a Masters in Engineering. At a Brooklyn printing plant, fluctuations in heat and moisture were causing the size of the printing paper to keep changing slightly, making it hard to align different colours. Carrier's invention made it possible to control temperature and humidity levels and so align the colours. The invention also allowed industries such as film, processed food, textiles and pharmaceuticals to improve the quality of their products.

In 1914, the first air-conditioning device was installed in a private house. However, its size, similar to that of an early computer, meant it took up too much space to come into widespread use, and later models, such as the Weathermaker, which Carrier brought out in the 1920s, cost too much for most people. Cooling for human comfort, rather than industrial need, really took off when three air conditioners were installed in the J.L. Hudson Department Store in Detroit, Michigan. People crowded into the shop to experience the new invention. The fashion spread from department stores to cinemas, whose income rose steeply as a result of the comfort they provided.

To start with, money-conscious employers regarded air conditioning as a luxury. They considered that if they were paying people to work, they should not be paying for them to be comfortable as well. So in the 1940s and '50s, the industry started putting out a different message about its product: according to their research, installing air conditioning increased productivity amongst employees. They found that typists increased their

output by 24% when transferred from a regular office to a cooled one. Another study into office working conditions, which was carried out in the late '50s, showed that the majority of companies cited air conditioning as the single most important contributor to efficiency in offices.

However, air conditioning has its critics. Jed Brown, an environmentalist, complains that air conditioning is a factor in global warming. Unfortunately, he adds, because air conditioning leads to higher temperatures, people have to use it even more. However, he admits that it provides a healthier environment for many people in the heat of summer.

30. When Willis Carrier invented air conditioning, his aim was to

- A make workers feel cooler.
- B produce more attractive paper.
- C set up a new business.
- D solve problems in a factory.

31. Home air conditioners were not popular at first because they were

- A too big and expensive.
- B not considered necessary.
- C too inefficient.
- D complicated to use.

32. Employers refused to put air conditioning in workplaces at first because they

- A could not afford to pay for it.
- B thought it was more suitable for cinemas.
- C did not want to spend money improving working conditions.
- D thought people would not work so hard in comfortable conditions.

33. What was the purpose of the research done in the 1940s and '50s?

- A to make office workers produce more
- B to compare different types of air conditioner
- C to persuade businesses to buy air conditioners
- D to encourage employees to change offices

34. What does Jed Brown say about air conditioning?

- A In future, everyone will need it.
- B Turning it off will not reduce global warming.
- C It can seriously damage people's health.
- D It is good for people, but bad for the environment.

IELTS Reading Worksheet

Band 4–5 | Skills: skimming, scanning, synonyms, locating information

Name: _____

Class: _____

Date: _____

Score: _____

Before you answer: Reading strategy checklist

1. Skim the title and first sentence of each paragraph to understand the topic.
2. Read the questions and underline keywords: names, numbers, places, dates, nouns.
3. Scan the text for the keyword or its synonym/paraphrase.
4. Underline the proof in the passage before writing the answer.

Passage 1: Deforestation and Desertification

Quick vocabulary support

zone = area | marginal = not very good / not very productive | semi-arid = very dry but not fully desert
deteriorate = become worse | drought = long time without rain | irreversible = cannot be changed back

A The Sahel zone lies between the Sahara desert and the fertile savannahs of northern Nigeria and southern Sudan. The word sahel comes from Arabic and means marginal or transitional, and this is a good description of these semi-arid lands, which occupy much of the West African countries of Mali, Mauritania, Niger and Chad.

B Unfortunately, over the last century the Sahara desert has steadily crept southwards, eating into once productive Sahel lands. United Nations surveys show that over 70 percent of the dry land in agricultural use in Africa has deteriorated over the last 30 years. Droughts have become more prolonged and more severe, the most recent lasting over 20 years in parts of the Sahel region. The same process of desertification is taking place across southern Africa as the Kalahari desert advances into Botswana and parts of South Africa.

C One of the major causes of this desert advance is poor agricultural land use, driven by the pressures of increasing population. Overgrazing – keeping too many farm animals on the land – means that grasses and other plants cannot recover, and scarce water supplies are exhausted. Overcultivation – trying to grow too many crops on poor land – results in the soil becoming even less fertile and drier, and beginning to break up. Soil erosion follows, and the land turns into desert.

D Another cause of desertification is loss of tree cover. Trees are cut down for use as fuel and to clear land for agricultural use. Tree roots help to bind the soil together, to conserve moisture and to provide a habitat for other plants and animals. When trees are cut down, the soil begins to dry and loosen, wind and rain erosion increase, other plant species die and eventually the fertile topsoil may be almost entirely lost, leaving only bare rock and dust.

E The effects of loss of topsoil and increased drought are irreversible. They are, however, preventable. Careful conservation of tree cover and sustainable agricultural land use have been shown to halt deterioration of soils and lessen the effects of shortage of rainfall. One project in Kita in south-west Mali funded by the UNDP has involved local communities in sustainable management of forest, while at the same time providing a viable agricultural economy based on the production of soaps, beekeeping and marketing shea nuts. This may be a model for similar projects in other West African countries.

Questions 1–6: Note Completion

Complete the notes below. Write **NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS** from the passage for each answer.

1. The climate of the Sahel is described as _____.
2. In some areas of the Sahel, there has been no rainfall for more than _____.
3. Desertification is caused by overgrazing, but this in turn is due to pressure from _____.
4. Where trees are cut down, the soil is affected, which leads to the death of the surrounding _____.
5. The consequences of the loss of topsoil cannot be reversed, but they are _____.
6. Looking after trees reduces the consequences of a lack of _____.

Questions 7–13: True / False / Not Given

Write TRUE / FALSE / NOT GIVEN

TRUE = the statement agrees with the information in the passage.

FALSE = the statement contradicts the information in the passage.

NOT GIVEN = there is not enough information in the passage.

7. The Sahara has spread slowly northwards into the Sahel region. _____
8. Just over 70 percent of the dry land in agricultural use in Africa has deteriorated over the last 30 years. _____
9. Desertification is taking place faster in southern Africa than in the Sahel. _____
10. The advance of the desert is not the result of poor agricultural land use. _____
11. The loss of tree cover is a minor cause of desertification. _____
12. If there is a loss of tree cover, the deterioration in the soil is halted. _____
13. Tree conservation is more effective than sustainable agricultural land use in reducing the consequences of lack of rain. _____

Passage 2: Music and Education

Quick vocabulary support

perception = view / opinion | marginalize = treat as less important | plethora = a large number

coordination = using different body parts together | fundamental = basic and very important

A Even the Greeks couldn't agree about it. Was music a source of order and proportion in society, regulating its innate chaos in ways similar to the disciplines of geometry and architecture? Or did its ability to express passionate emotions beyond the reach of words create the potential for disorder and anarchy? Compare the behaviour of an audience listening to classical string quartets with headbangers at a rave, and the age-old conflict between Apollo and Dionysus is made manifest all over again in our own time.

B Shakespeare, though, came clean. For him, "the man who hath no music in himself, Nor is not mov'd with concord of sweet sounds, Is fit for treasons, stratagems and spoils; The motions of his spirit are dull as night ..." Throughout his plays, Shakespeare perceives music as a healing force, an art whose practice makes man whole.

C Yet, despite the growth of the science of music therapy within the last two centuries, and despite the huge weight of books published on the miraculous "Mozart effect", our schools and colleges have fallen strangely silent. The so-called "Mozart effect" presents anecdotal and statistical evidence for advances in both social and academic skills in those children exposed in their formative years to the music of Mozart. But, in an age obsessed by pragmatism and by short-term vocational learning, music has been marginalized in both primary and secondary education. Compared with the holy trinity of reading, writing and arithmetic, music is regarded as an unimportant pastime. As a result, children are leaving school not only totally ignorant of their own musical heritage, but lacking in social, physical and mental skills which musical performance can uniquely promote.

D Playing an instrument requires a degree of concentration and coordination which brings into play a plethora of mental and physical skills which are being eroded in our push-button world. Socialization and teamwork are also involved. Schools with wind bands, string ensembles, jazz groups and orchestras are right up there at the top of the league tables. In excelling in musical activity, the students' performance in many other fields of learning is refocused and radically improved.

E There are medical aspects too. Long before British primary schools discovered the recorder – that most basic of all modern woodwind instruments – Australian Aborigines had developed the didgeridoo. Like the clarinet and the flute, this haunting and beautiful instrument helped to overcome both upper and lower respiratory tract problems and encouraged better sleep. In playing a wind instrument, abdominal muscles are used to support the breathing system. And these are the very muscles which come into play when an asthmatic is experiencing an attack.

F But what of those individuals and schools which simply cannot afford a musical instrument? What of those institutions where not a single member of staff can read music? This is where the human being's most primitive form of music-making comes into its own. Singing is free. Everyone possesses a voice. And, with it, the body expresses itself in the most fundamental and organic way.

G The Hungarian composer Zoltan Kodaly knew this, and developed his own system of training ear and voice within a simple yet comprehensive system of body language. Today, an organization called The Voices

Foundation adapts and applies Kodaly's methods, aiming to give children back their singing voices, and to make our schools ring with music-making once again. Their advisors and teachers have already achieved extraordinary turn-around effects the length and breadth of Britain and in schools in the troubled areas of South Africa.

H Important work is currently being done in Finland, Israel and the United States on pre-school, even pre-birth, musical education. Music in the womb is very much part of the life of the unborn future citizens of Finland. And one has only to look at the educational standards, health records and professional musical activity in this small nation to see what dividends music in education pays from the earliest days of human life.

I Mozart has been celebrated in his anniversary years of 1991 and again in 2006. By the time of the next Mozart-Year, shall we have allowed music to conjure a better society for us all? Or, relegated to the ranks of mere entertainment, will music be eroded of its unique power to heal and to make whole?

Questions 14–20: Matching Headings

The reading passage has nine paragraphs, A–I. Choose the best headings for paragraphs B–H from the list below. Paragraph A has been done for you.

- | | |
|---|--|
| i. The effect of emphasis on short-term educational goals | viii. Early exposure to music in the USA |
| ii. The limited effects of music | ix. Music without instruments |
| iii. The future of music | x. The "Mozart effect" |
| iv. Benefits for health | xi. Order or chaos |
| v. The effects of early exposure to music | xii. The creation of The Voices Foundation |
| vi. The skills involved in musical activity | xiii. A method for training singers |
| vii. A playwright's perception of music | xiv. The use of music in Shakespeare's plays |

Example: Paragraph A = xi

14. Paragraph B _____
15. Paragraph C _____
16. Paragraph D _____
17. Paragraph E _____
18. Paragraph F _____
19. Paragraph G _____
20. Paragraph H _____

Questions 21–23: Yes / No / Not Given

Write YES / NO / NOT GIVEN

YES = the statement agrees with the writer's claims.

NO = the statement contradicts the writer's claims.

NOT GIVEN = it is impossible to say what the writer thinks about this.

21. In Shakespeare's dramas, music is seen in a positive light. _____

22. Schools lack the funds to buy luxury items like musical instruments. _____

23. Musical activity can only lead to a slight improvement in children's social, physical and mental skills.

Questions 24–26: Yes / No / Not Given

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

24. According to the writer, studying music

A may not help all students to improve in other areas of their studies.

B means that students spend less time on reading, writing and arithmetic.

C helps students to improve enormously in other areas of their studies.

D means that students will excel as professional musicians.

25. The didgeridoo is an instrument that

A has a negative effect on those suffering with breathing problems.

B benefits those suffering with breathing problems.

C tends to send those who listen to it to sleep.

D sounds sad to most people.

26. Which of the following is the most suitable heading for Reading Passage 2?

A The growth of music in the school curriculum

B Music throughout the ages

C Music for everyone

D The beneficial effects of a musical education